Upbound – Senior Product Marketing Manager

Hi Upbound hiring team,

What drew me to this role was the Modelplane launch in June. The framing Bassam used, "inference doesn't stay on one cluster," is the right product insight to build a market around, an engineer naming a real problem that every company running open-weight models at scale is about to run into. The PMM opportunity here is to build the category narrative and sales motion before any analyst has named what Upbound is doing with Modelplane, the same way the Crossplane team built the "cloud-native control plane" category before Gartner had a quadrant for it. That's the kind of problem I have spent my career preparing to work on.

I have spent the last seven years doing GTM and product marketing for B2B SaaS and product-led companies, typically as the first or early marketing hire, typically in categories where the market framing wasn't obvious at the start. At Reform, I led the repositioning of a developer-facing form and onboarding platform, built the PLG messaging architecture, and drove a 34% lift in trial activation and a 21% improvement in trial-to-paid conversion by tightening who we were talking to and making the category claim specific enough to be defensible. At Hank Robotics, I built the positioning, ICP, and messaging playbooks from scratch in a technically unfamiliar category, AI-powered drone robotics, and contributed to 1,900% MQL growth in three months. At FunnelEnvy, I built the ABM playbook and sales enablement system that lifted enterprise meeting bookings 31%. The consistent thread across all three: I ramp fast into technically unfamiliar categories and get the positioning and sales motion working before the company has the luxury of waiting for a bigger team.

I have experience marketing to the engineers who run infrastructure. At Reform, I wrote messaging for platform engineers and built the developer-facing positioning. I also run a technical stack of my own: a self-hosted n8n instance on a Google Cloud virtual machine behind Docker and Traefik, plus Claude Code and custom agents for outbound prospecting, lifecycle automation, and campaign reporting. That practice will make me credible in conversations with engineers who need to trust that marketing understands what they're building.

I am also genuinely interested in the community-to-commercial narrative challenge. The Crossplane community is already 1,000+ organizations and 100M downloads. The PMM job for Modelplane is to give that community a clear, trusted explanation of what the commercial product adds without turning the community relationship into a sales funnel. That tension between community content that's genuinely useful and neutral, and commercial content that closes enterprise deals, is one I understand structurally from working in PLG environments where the community member is often the enterprise buyer.

I would welcome the chance to talk through how I'd approach the first 90 days. The strategy hypothesis I've written alongside this application lays out where I'd start: the commercial positioning document, the community-to-commercial bridge content, the competitive comparison frame, and the analyst briefings that establish "fleet-level AI inference management" as a named category before someone else names it.

Thank you for your time. I look forward to hearing from you.

James Praise

P.S. I've created a portfolio focused on this role at jamespraise.xyz/work/upbound.